

Film/Animation Aesthetics

Dr Niles Qi Li
Assistant Professor in Film Studies

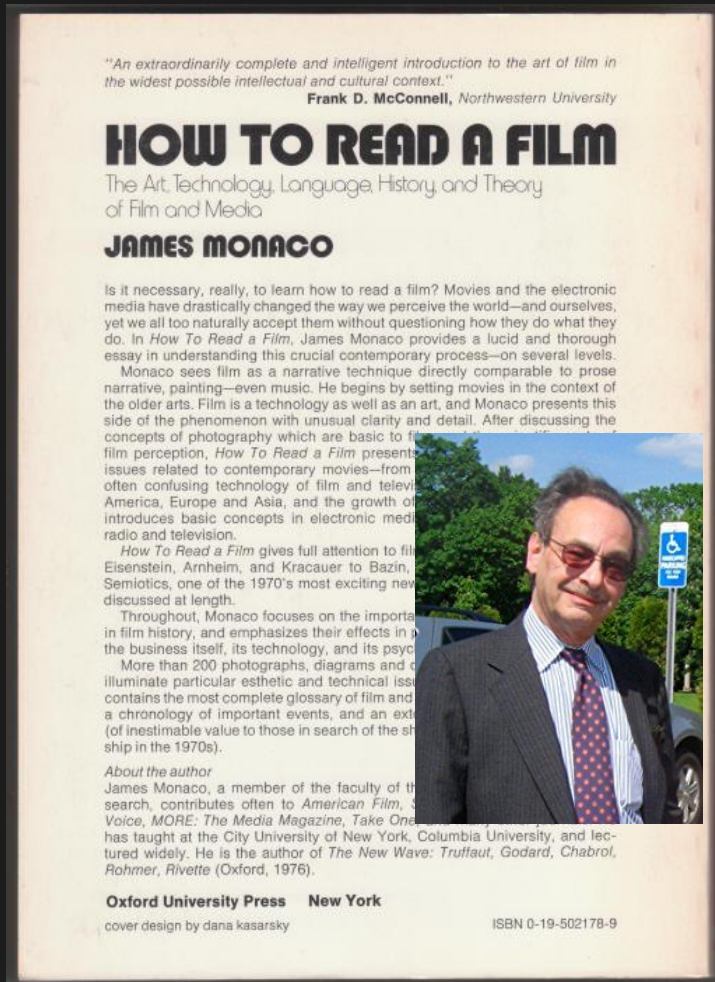


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Course intro (please enter your ISpace) and my short bio

Movie, Film, Cinema. (for French theorists)



The "filmic" is that aspect of the art that concerns its relationship with the world around it;

The "cinematic" deals strictly with the esthetics and internal structure of the art.

But in general we use these three names for the art in a way that closely parallels this differentiation:

- "movies," like popcorn, are to be consumed;
- "cinema" (at least in American parlance) is high art, redolent of esthetics; Here, we can think about queer cinema, avant-garde cinema, and third cinema (these concepts)
- "film" is the most general term with the fewest connotations.

The history of movies/film/cinema is rich and complex, although it spans only a century.

- as a medium of communication it was immediately apprehensible to large numbers of people
- a matter of the geometric progression of technology in the twentieth century coupled with economic cycles
- or, film as an art form (say, for instance, David Bordwell)

Term, historical use, theoretical paradigm, and the ways we unfold film/cinema/movie.

So, the next step is what is aesthetics?

Consider it in terms of general meaning for the public, and theoretical implications for scholars

Aesthetics

broad definitions of aesthetics, such as “the philosophical inquiry into art and beauty”, or something to that effect.

Nickolas Pappas

What is evaluative aesthetics?

17

1.1 The origin and definition of aesthetics

The concept of the ‘aesthetic’ is best considered as a cluster of interrelated meanings, and Part I will attempt to elaborate its multifaceted nature. Its Greek origin is *aisthesis*, meaning perception by sense, or feeling; more precisely it derives ‘from the Greek nominal *aisthetikos*, sensitive or sentient, derived in turn from the verb *aisthanesthai*, meaning to perceive, feel, or sense’ (Costelloe 2013: 1). *Aesthetiki* is ‘the science of how things are known to the senses’ and *aisthema* is ‘the sensation of any object’ (Day 2010: 155). To perceive is to become aware of something through the senses and not only through sight. Thinking in terms of sense perception also links aesthetics to experience: the importance of the experience of the object before us.

Andrew Klevan

AESTHETIC
EVALUATION
AND FILM
ANDREW KLEVAN



James Shelley writes that “the term ‘aesthetic’ has come to be used to designate, among other things, a kind of object, a kind of judgment, a kind of attitude, a kind of experience, and a kind of value”

[for] the most part, aesthetic theories have divided over questions particular to one or another of these designations: whether artworks are necessarily aesthetic objects; how to square the allegedly perceptual basis of aesthetic judgments with the fact that we give reasons in support of them; how best to capture the elusive contrast between an aesthetic attitude and a practical one; whether to define aesthetic experience according to its phenomenological or representational content; how best to understand the relation between aesthetic value and aesthetic experience.



"The Concept of the Aesthetic", *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*

James Shelley



What is Film Aesthetics by Zachary Xavier

What might be understood as an aesthetic of film extends back almost to the origins of the medium, and much of what we identify as film theory could be understood as having some aesthetic concern, either as a consideration of film as an art or as a part of the realm of the sensible or the beautiful.

It is important not to fall prey to a popular misconception... that aesthetics is equivalent to Formalism: an adherence to form at the expense of content (for example, subject matter). Nor is it equivalent to Aestheticism if this is taken to mean an exaggerated devotion to beautiful forms, once again at the expense of content. (20)

As we have seen, then, film aesthetics is a nuanced subfield of film studies. Indeed, an aesthetic study of film can be approached in various ways, and can implicate ideas beyond immediate aesthetic interests. This is reflected in the works of many thinkers that have contributed to contemplating this topic throughout the short history of cinema. In my next article, I have compiled a list of some of the key figures and texts in the field of film aesthetics, each accompanied with a brief overview, for those wanting to research this area of film studies further.

Scholars normally approach cinema or films in terms of “content” and “style.”

“Content is understood as the representational—elements that refer to the real world outside the film. This is mostly approached in terms of narrative and characters.

Style, also known as “form,” is understood as those elements that cannot be said to refer mimetically to a world outside the film, such as editing. “



Postsocialist Cinema in Post-Mao China

*The Cultural Revolution
after the Cultural Revolution*

 Chris Berry

Get a little more abstract and ask other questions:

By what principles is a film put together?

How do various parts relate to one another to create a whole?

Before asking questions, we need to understand the starting point.

We assume that a film is not a random collection of elements.

Some overall logic governs the relations among parts, and a pattern exists there.

So, film scholars turn to another term “film form”, or “cinematic form”.

The system of relationships among parts we shall call **form**.

To counter our common sense:

The aesthetic evaluation of film therefore is concerned with how a film communicates *as a film*, by way of images and sounds, and more particularly by way of, for example, the screenwriter, the director, the camera, the actors, the costumes, the location, the lighting, and the mode of recording and reception.

“This is a good film” does not simply refer to merit; it does not only mean that this film is *good*, but that it is a good *film*. It is a good example of a category, namely film. The claim is about a film as distinct from a claim about a novel or a play or a piece of music.

In the desire to distinguish film from **other art forms**, there was also a tendency in early film theory to make claims for *unique* properties.

André Bazin (1918–58) thought that photographic realism was the pre-eminent feature of film and therefore he valued films that took advantage of this to explore reality. (**continuity of reality**)



Rudolf Arnheim (1904–2007) prioritised film's ability to manipulate: it is too easy to rely on film's photographic basis and therefore the good film must find ways to imaginatively shape reality. (**the veracity of reality**)



Sergei Eisenstein (1898–1948) emphasised the medium's facility for montage and stark juxtaposition, between, and within, frames. This would produce collisions in the composition and shocks to a viewer that would stimulate new ideas. (**change our ideas about reality**)

Most arts share properties, however, and a medium is usually made up of many media. Film is particularly hybrid. It combines, for example, storytelling (novel), performance, costume, set (theatre), composition (painting), images of the world (photography), and sounds (music), and it is difficult, if not impossible, to pinpoint what is unique to it

To understand the film aesthetics, we are in need of the detailed study of film style and form.

for instance, narrative structure, use of camera, colour, performance, sound, music, editing and composition; matters of philosophical aesthetics, and their particular application to film.

This also means that a film is not simply a random batch of elements. Like all artworks, a film has form. By form, in its broadest sense, we mean the overall set of relationships among a film's parts.

1. The first step: to acquire a set of analytical terms and articulate your thoughts of films
2. The second phase: to use your own way to visualise the thoughts, aka., to turn your thoughts into the cinematic

Film Studies

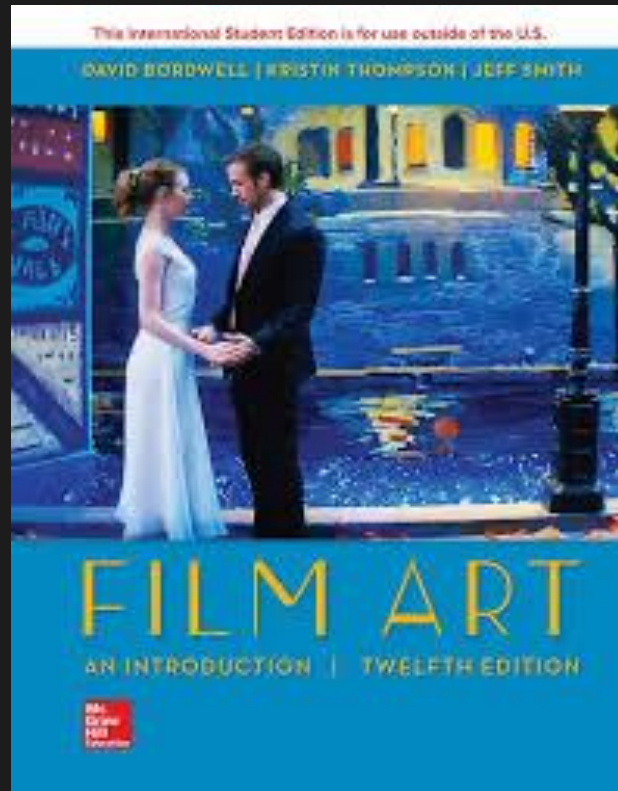
Vs. Film (meta)criticism or ordinary discourse

Evaluative work × But, subjective investment ✓

Ahistorical × So, put a film in the contexts of film history ✓

Not analytical × dissect strategies of plotting or aspects of style or theories ✓

Just narrative (or just story) and personal feeling × Cinematic forms +Affects ✓



<https://www.davidbordwell.net/essays/studying.php>

• David Bordwell's website on cinema

Studying Cinema

2000

People talk about the movies they see, and some people write about those movies for newspapers and magazines. How does thinking about film aren't completely distinct, I think, but some differences are worth noting.

Animation aesthetics and film aesthetics are often aligned, but they also present distinct characteristics and conventions that set them apart. Both share fundamental elements of visual storytelling, such as narrative structure, cinematography, composition, and mise-en-scène, but animation adds its own layer of creativity and flexibility that traditional live-action film may not always allow.

The term "animated film" is not typically considered a genre in the academic sense, but rather a medium or form of filmmaking. Animation refers to the technique used to create moving images through the manipulation of static images, which can include 2D hand-drawn animation, 3D computer-generated imagery (CGI), stop-motion, claymation, and more. It encompasses a wide range of genres, just as live-action film does.

Similarities:

1. Visual Composition and Cinematography: Both animation and traditional film rely on principles of visual composition, such as framing, lighting, colour theory, and movement. Animators, like filmmakers, carefully construct shots to evoke emotional responses and create atmosphere.

2. Narrative Structures: Just as in conventional cinema, animation adheres to classical narrative structures (e.g., three-act structure) and can express a range of genres—drama, comedy, horror, etc.

3. Aesthetic Choices: Both forms involve choices about style (realistic or stylized) and tone, contributing to the visual language that defines each film.

Differences:

1.Freedom of Representation: Animation offers unparalleled flexibility in depicting worlds, characters, and actions. Unlike live-action films, animated films are not restricted by physical realism, allowing for more experimental visual forms. This flexibility allows for highly stylized or exaggerated aesthetics that are not possible in traditional cinema.

2.Emphasis on Movement and Transformation: In animation, movement can be hyper-exaggerated or defy the laws of physics entirely. This often leads to a unique aesthetic experience that is distinct from the realism sought in many live-action films.

3.Medium-Specific Visual Strategies: Animation can incorporate a variety of mediums—such as hand-drawn, stop-motion, or computer-generated imagery (CGI)—which bring distinct visual languages and artistic choices into the aesthetic equation. These strategies open up new possibilities in storytelling that might not align with the more standardized techniques in traditional filmmaking.

Three Major Anime

- *One Piece* is a long-running manga and anime series known for its epic story, colorful characters, and thrilling action.
- *Naruto* tells the story of ninjas and their struggles, friendships, and growth. It has a dedicated fan base and has inspired many spin-offs and adaptations.
- *Dragon Ball* is a classic anime series that has been popular for decades. It is known for its fast-paced action, humor, and memorable characters. Although it was not explicitly mentioned in the provided references, it is commonly included in discussions of the three major hot-blooded anime.

These three anime series are renowned for their exciting storylines, powerful characters, and inspiring themes of friendship, courage, and perseverance.

改编自阅文集团旗下起点中文网《牧神记》

作者：宅猪



牧神记

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制作 玄机
SPARKKEY



Mononoke the Movie: Phantom in the Rain is a 2024 Japanese animated supernatural psychological horror film written and directed by Kenji Nakamura with Kōji Yamamoto as a co-writer; the film is based on the *Mononoke* anime television series (2007), which in turn is a spin-off of *Ayakashi: Samurai Horror Tales* anthology series (2006), both created by Toei Animation. Produced by EOTA and co-distributed by Giggly Box and Twin Engine, *Phantom in the Rain* is the first part of the *Mononoke* trilogy film project

The series *Mononoke* takes its name from spirits that bind themselves to powerful human emotions. The Medicine Seller, protagonist of the series, possesses a sword capable of quelling them. However, in order to wield it, he must discover the form, truth, and reason of each *mononoke*—its original human name, what caused it to turn, and the reason for its emotional turmoil.

The 2007 animated television series *Mononoke* laid the groundwork for the story.

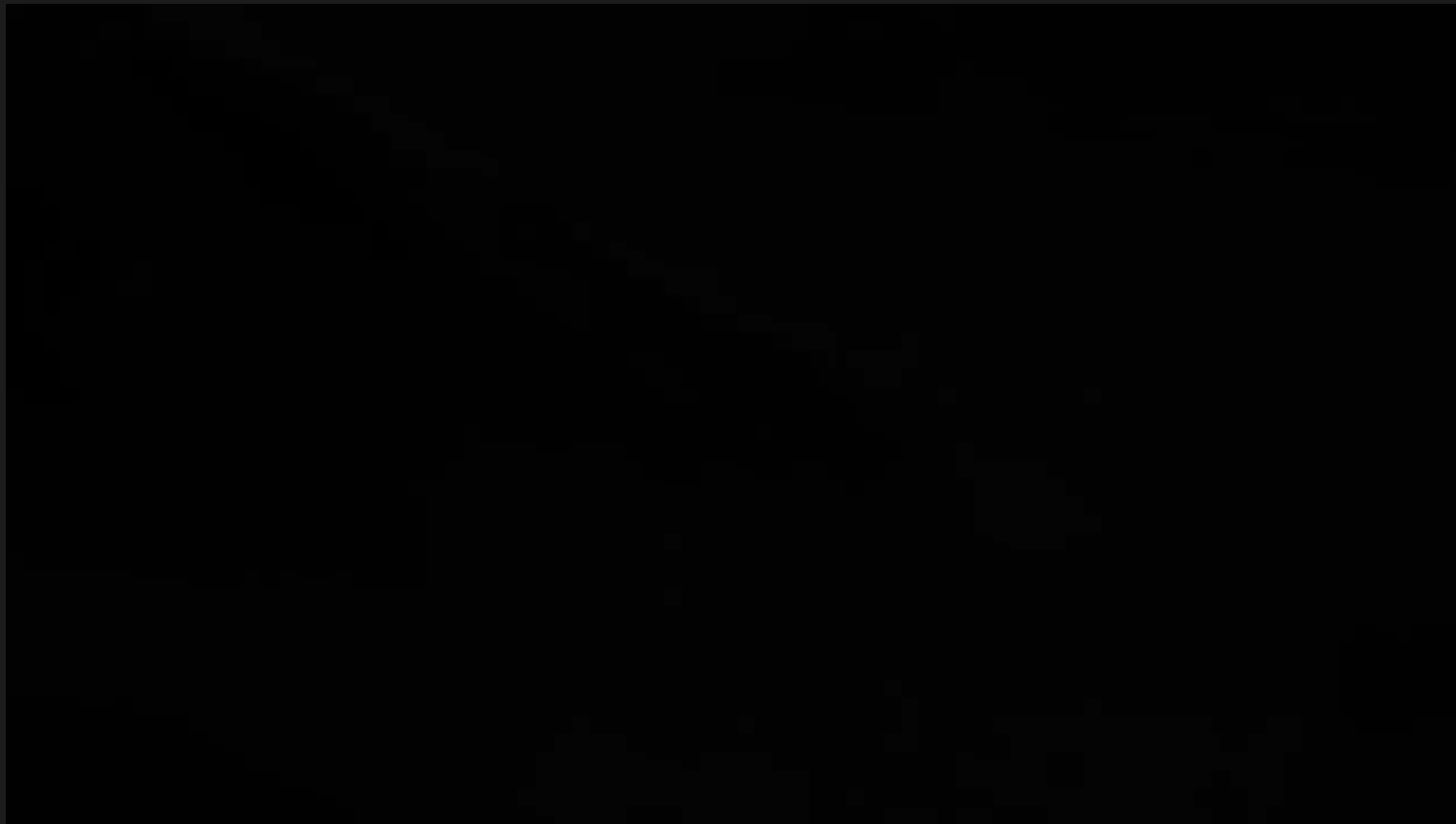
The **anime's stylish look** incorporates motifs from ukiyo-e prints and washi paper for a distinctively Japanese taste, with scripts utilizing horror and mystery as the backdrop for evocatively rich human dramas. The series enjoyed great popularity during and after its broadcast run, and found no shortage of fans abroad.

Ukiyo-e (浮世絵) is a genre of Japanese art that flourished from the 17th through 19th centuries. Its artists produced woodblock prints and paintings of such subjects as female beauties; kabuki actors and sumo wrestlers; scenes from history and folk tales; travel scenes and landscapes; flora and fauna; and erotica.



Washi (和紙) is traditional Japanese paper processed by hand using fibers from the inner bark of the gampi tree, the mitsumata shrub (*Edgeworthia chrysantha*), or the paper mulberry (*kōzo*) bush. Washi is generally tougher than ordinary paper made from wood pulp, and is used in many traditional arts. Origami, shodō, and ukiyo-e were all produced using washi.





闽南、台湾 金光/霹雳布袋戏

Puppetry is a form of theatre or performance that involves the manipulation of puppets – inanimate objects, often resembling some type of human or animal figure, that are animated or manipulated by a human called a puppeteer. Such a performance is also known as a puppet production.





